Roughly eight weeks from now, Madhya Pradesh, which came into being on November 1, 1956, will complete 66 years of its existence. The state's creation marked the coming together of distinct geographical regions such as Bundelkhand, Baghelkhand, Mahakoshal, Madhya Bharat, Malwa, Nimar, Chhattisgarh and the Part C state of Bhopal. Except for Chhattisgarh, which was carved into a new state in 2000, all the other constituents of Madhya Pradesh—even with their distinct dialects, food habits and culture—have remained steadfast to the idea of the state.

Meanwhile, radical changes have come about in many spheres, showcasing transformations for the better. Agriculture has continued to be the prime economic activity of the state right from its early days. Since the primary sector had the largest chunk of the population engaged in it—as it still does—agriculture also dominates the politics of the state.

Crucially, Madhya Pradesh's criticality to the India story is now coming to the fore. The state has pledged a greater role in accomplishing the $5 trillion economy target of the country, with Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan committing to a contribution of $550 billion to it.

Besides the rapid strides in agriculture, emerging as a top producer of several crops, and pushing up farm incomes in the process, the state is also evolving into an industrial hub, with textiles, auto parts and food processing doing well in the past few years.

MADHYA PRADESH HAS PLEDGED A GREATER ROLE IN ACCOMPLISHING INDIA'S TARGET TO BECOME A $5 TRILLION-ECONOMY

Madhya Pradesh is also a pioneer in various governance models and boasts of many social sector schemes such as Ladli Laxmi, Kanyadan Yojana and Sambal that have been emulated, under different names, by states such as Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Jharkhand and Delhi—an indicator of their success.

The state is endowed with rich natural resources and is home to some of the best-run national parks in the country—from tiger reserves in Kanha, Bandhavgarh, Panna, Pench, Satpura, Sanjay-Dubri to Madhav National Park, the list is endless. The tourism potential has just begun to be unlocked. Uniquely located in the centre of India, Madhya Pradesh also has the potential to become a logistics hub.

Education, job creation and the environment are some of the other areas in which the state has set itself ambitious targets. To ensure quality education for schoolchildren, the state is in the process of setting up CM RISE schools, a network of educational institutions that will uld provide all amenities associated with private schools to children from marginalised backgrounds. Madhya Pradesh has set itself a target of providing more than three million jobs through schemes that encourage self-employment as well as in government sectors. The state is at the forefront of the effort to move to green energy with some of the biggest and most unique solar power projects being commissioned. For example, a floating 600 MW project has been announced, which will be located at the Omkareshwar dam on the Narmada.

Speaking at the India Today State of the States Madhya Pradesh Conclave at Bhopal on August 22, Chief Minister Chouhan said that Madhya Pradesh, clocking a growth of 19.8 per cent in its GSDP, is one of the fastest-growing economies in the country. "MP's share in the country's GDP has grown from 3.6 per cent to 4.6 per cent in two decades," he said, elaborating on the economic growth seen in the state.

However, the most comforting thought is that even as Madhya Pradesh pursues its rightful place among the various states that constitute the Union of India, the virtues that characterise a 'Madhya Pradeshi'—that of contentment and welcoming all those who come in to make the state their home—remain intact. ■



Chief Minister **Shivraj Singh Chouhan** *addresses the India Today State of the States Madhya Pradesh Conclave in Bhopal as India Today Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa looks on*